



world's most recognisable and admired athletes.

In *RAFA*, Ana Maria said, "The most important thing, now that I see fame has not gone to his head, and never will, is to make him feel at peace when he is home. He needs peace because that is the last thing he has when he is away on tour..."

In 2022, Nadal told *Essential Sport* about his mother's crucial role during his exhilarating but injury-plagued journey to the top.

"To underestimate the value of her role in everything that has come my way, to see her importance as less than Toni's, for example, would be as blind as it would be unjust."

Nadal's wife, who seems to be the antithesis of Mirka Federer, played no role in the Spaniard's career for several years and relished her anonymity and independence, working full-time at an insurance company.

She seldom travelled with him because, as she put it, "even if I could, [it] would not be good either for him

or for me."

She never speaks to the media, and said in the memoir, "Even if my family asks me about Rafael, I prefer not to say much... It's what works for me, and what works for Rafael and me as a couple. We wouldn't have it any other way."

Today, Mery, who holds a degree in business administration, serves as the Project Director of Strategy and Relations with Institutions for the Rafa Nadal Foundation.

Big Three bonanza

Whenever the legendary Big Three clashed at a Grand Slam event, we were guaranteed a stellar

La familia: Nadal celebrates his 2019 Davis Cup triumph with his mother, wife, and sister (left-right), along with his father (top right).

performance from at least one of them. And when both played at their dazzling best, particularly in a final, they produced matches for the ages. Here are the crème de la crème:

🏆 **Nadal def. Federer 6-4, 6-4, 6-7, 6-7, 9-7 — 2008 Wimbledon final**

So dominant were No. 1 Federer and No. 2 Nadal that they had combined to win 14 of the previous 16 Major championships leading into the 2008 Wimbledon. The Mighty Fed had seized five successive Big W titles

« With 81 consecutive victories on clay, Nadal has the longest winning streak on a single surface among men »